

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action

2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Laura Babitt

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council, District 1

1. Housing Element

I believe Berkeley needs more housing and more housing opportunities at different income levels. Our Housing Element mandates the development of 8,934 homes through 2031, while also preserving existing housing, encouraging affordable housing, advancing equity, protecting tenants, and furthering fair housing. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

My responsibility as a Councilmember is to ensure the fulfillment of these requirements, while listening closely to the communities directly affected by major land-use decisions. these goals while listening to the communities affected by major land-use decisions. I believe successful housing policy should increase housing opportunities, create affordability, prevent displacement, and strengthen neighborhoods.

a. San Pablo Specific Plan

I believe San Pablo Avenue provides significant opportunities for additional housing because of its transit, services, and commercial uses. I want to promote growth that includes affordable and workforce housing, while establishing long term community benefits.

The Specific Plan provides an opportunity to create public plazas and open space, wider and more welcoming sidewalks, trees and landscaping, safer crossings, transportation improvements, and infrastructure while supporting the small businesses that make the corridor unique.

I believe residents and businesses should have a meaningful role in shaping how their neighborhood grows. Thoughtful development creates housing and supports vibrancy along San Pablo Avenue and its surrounding neighborhoods. while creating a stronger San Pablo Avenue and stronger surrounding neighborhoods.

b. North Shattuck, Solano, and College Avenue

I believe Berkeley should expand housing opportunities throughout the city, including in neighborhoods that historically have had fewer multifamily and affordable housing opportunities.

I would approach zoning changes by engaging the people who live and work in these communities while paying special attention to affordability, existing businesses, infrastructure, transportation, accessibility, and neighborhood context.

My goal would be to expand access to housing while creating development that complements and strengthens these commercial districts and surrounding neighborhoods.

c. Middle housing and the Hills

I believe middle housing can provide more housing choices and allow duplexes, triplexes, fourplexes, and other smaller multifamily homes in neighborhoods that historically have had fewer such opportunities.

Berkeley's current middle-housing rules allow two-to-six-unit projects in most primarily residential areas while excluding the high-fire-hazard areas of the Berkeley Hills. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

For the Hills, I believe decisions about additional housing should incorporate wildfire risk, evacuation capacity, emergency access, and infrastructure. Housing planning and public-safety planning should work together, with residents and public-safety professionals helping shape solutions appropriate for those neighborhoods.

d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

I believe affirmatively furthering fair housing means creating genuine housing opportunities throughout Berkeley for people with different incomes and backgrounds.

That includes producing deeply affordable and workforce housing, preserving existing affordable units, protecting residents from displacement, using public land strategically, leveraging state and federal funding, partnering with nonprofit and mission-driven developers, and creating opportunities for homeownership.

As a Berkeley School Board Director, I helped advance educator housing because the people serving our community increasingly could not afford to live here. We also worked with surrounding neighbors to address their concerns and shape the project, including limiting the additional building height to 6 stories.

That experience reinforced my belief that building housing and listening to communities can go hand in hand.

2. Climate Action Plan

I believe Berkeley should continue to be a leader in addressing climate change, and our strategies should make sustainable choices practical and accessible for the entire

community. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan calls for an 80% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions from 2000 levels by 2050 and envisions sustainable transportation, cleaner buildings, renewable energy, waste reduction, and climate resilience. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

My commitment to climate action is reflected in my governing record. As a Berkeley School Board Director, I sponsored the Climate Literacy and Environmental Justice Resolution, reinvigorated implementation of the District's Sustainability Plan, and helped turn those goals into everyday practices, including implementing reusable dishes in several schools to reduce waste.

Transportation and buildings are central to Berkeley's climate goals. I believe we should expand reliable public transportation, create safe pedestrian and bicycle networks, encourage cleaner vehicles, improve EV infrastructure, transition buildings toward cleaner energy, expand our tree canopy, and build more housing near transit and everyday services. Berkeley's Electric Mobility Roadmap similarly combines electric transportation with increased walking, biking, and public transit while emphasizing equitable access. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

Equity and accessibility should remain central to implementation. Seniors, people with disabilities, families transporting children, tradespeople, caregivers, cyclists, transit riders, and people who depend on cars all need safe and practical ways to move through Berkeley.

I believe the strongest climate policies combine ambitious goals with practical implementation, community engagement, and equitable access to cleaner choices.

3. Most important City Council housing vote

I believe the adoption of **Middle Housing zoning** was one of Berkeley's most consequential housing decisions of the past four years. The Council adopted the changes in July 2025, allowing qualifying two-to-six-unit housing in most residential areas under streamlined standards. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

The underlying goal is important: housing opportunities should exist throughout Berkeley, including in neighborhoods that historically have had fewer multifamily housing options.

As these changes are implemented, I would focus on the outcomes. I want to know what types of homes are actually being produced, who can afford them, whether we are creating opportunities for families at different income levels, and how the changes affect existing residents.

I believe Berkeley should regularly evaluate its housing policies using real results and community feedback. My measure of success is whether our policies help more people find and remain in homes they can afford.

4. Most important climate or environmental issue

I believe one of the most important environmental challenges facing Berkeley is ensuring that our ambitious climate goals translate into meaningful and equitable action.

This is an area where I bring direct governing experience. As a Berkeley School Board Director, I sponsored the Climate Literacy and Environmental Justice Resolution and reinvigorated implementation of the District's Sustainability Plan. Climate policy should address both climate change and the reality that environmental impacts and burdens are not experienced equally throughout our communities.

I also believe policy must lead to implementation. During my time on the Board, we moved sustainability goals into everyday operations, including implementing reusable dishes in several schools to reduce waste.

Berkeley's own Climate Action Plan similarly connects environmental goals with equity, economic opportunity, and quality of life, and the City's building-electrification strategy specifically emphasizes affordable access and prioritizing communities most affected by climate change. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

On the City Council, I would bring the same approach: establish meaningful climate goals, consider environmental justice and affordability in our decisions, listen to affected communities, and focus on implementation and measurable results.

5. Adding homes while reducing GHG emissions

I believe housing, transportation, and climate planning should be connected. My experience implementing sustainability initiatives in Berkeley's public schools taught me that ambitious environmental goals become meaningful when they are translated into practical changes people can actually use.

Building more homes near transit, jobs, schools, commercial districts, and everyday services can give residents more transportation choices. I believe housing growth should be paired with investments in reliable public transit, safe walking and bicycle routes, EV infrastructure, trees, pedestrian improvements, and connections between neighborhoods. Transportation accounts for roughly 60% of Berkeley's greenhouse-gas emissions, making transportation choices an important part of the City's climate strategy. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

New development also provides opportunities for energy-efficient buildings, climate-resilient design, stormwater management, and infrastructure that supports lower-carbon transportation.

Different residents have different transportation needs. A senior traveling to a medical appointment, a teacher commuting early in the morning, a parent transporting children, and someone bicycling to work may each make different choices.

I want Berkeley to make lower-carbon transportation safe, convenient, accessible, and affordable enough that more people can choose it.

6. Pedestrian and cyclist safety

I believe everyone should be able to walk, bicycle, and travel through Berkeley safely.

I would prioritize data-driven improvements at dangerous intersections, school routes, and collision corridors. Depending upon the location, solutions could include protected bicycle facilities, bicycle boulevards, improved crossings, traffic calming, better lighting, signal improvements, sidewalk repairs, and other proven safety measures.

I also believe the people who use the street every day provide valuable information. Cyclists, pedestrians, disability advocates, residents, transit providers, emergency responders, and local businesses should have meaningful opportunities to participate in project design, and feel confident that their feedback will be integrated into the final proposal.

Different streets may call for different solutions. My approach would be to understand the safety problem, listen to the people affected, examine the available options, and implement solutions that improve safety and mobility for the community.

7. Inclusionary zoning

I believe inclusionary housing is an important tool for creating mixed-income communities and expanding affordable housing opportunities throughout Berkeley.

On-site affordable units can allow lower- and moderate-income households to live in neighborhoods where affordable opportunities have historically been limited. In-lieu fees can also create significant public benefit when those resources are combined with other funding to produce deeply affordable housing.

I believe Berkeley should use both approaches strategically and evaluate the actual results. Factors such as the number of affordable homes produced, depth of affordability, project feasibility, access to different neighborhoods, and opportunities to leverage outside funding should inform our decisions.

Public land, nonprofit partnerships, state and federal resources, preservation of existing affordable housing, and workforce housing can all contribute to affordability. Berkeley's Housing Element itself takes a broader approach that includes housing production, preservation, affordability, fair housing, equity, and tenant protections. ([The City of Berkeley](#))

My goal is more deeply affordable housing, broader access to housing opportunities throughout Berkeley, and stronger protections against displacement.